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THE MEANING OF HUMANITY AND THE UNBEARABLE EXISTENCE AS THE OTHER IN KAZUO ISHIGURO'S *NEVER LET ME GO*

Abstract

The world delineated by Kazuo Ishiguro in *Never Let Me Go* determines the reader to question the way in which the human body is perceived in a world dominated by technology. The intoxicating presence of technology has made cloning possible, which leads to understanding the meaning of humanity differently by either attesting what we already know or reassessing new significances. This paper attempts to prove the way in which cloning places the individual in a non-human position – a position of *otherness*, which leads to a reconfiguration of the concept of humanity.

Keywords: Kazuo Ishiguro, *Never Let Me Go*, otherness, the Other, humanity

“The god of machines and smelting furnaces, i.e. the energies of the spirits of nature, understood and applied in the service of higher egotism; it believes in correcting the world through knowledge, in life led by science; and it is truly capable of confining the individual within the smallest circle of solvable tasks.” (Nietzsche, 1999: 85)

1. Introduction

This paper intends to reflect on the meaning of humanity – a concept that is challenging to fully grasp – by analysing the way in which Ishiguro portrays it in his work *Never Let Me Go*. The novel introduces a dystopian scenario in which cloning is a prevalent practice, due to the noteworthy scientific development that characterised the 20th century. The status of the clone is thus assessed, as the cloned person is in the position of the marginalised individual – or the *Other*. Kathy – the biased narrator of the story, who is a clone, approaches a sympathetic stance towards humanity, which determines the reader to place under scrutiny the true meaning of this controversial concept. In a world in which science seems to reign, it is quintessential to ask ourselves what the true essence of humanity is, and to determine whether sacrifices are worth being made in an attempt to defy disease and death or not.

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2. Hailsham – A Paradoxical, Dystopian Realm

Never Let Me Go urges the reader to think, ask questions and meditate on the fluid character of identity, on the status of the self that is granted by the meaning of origin, and on the traumatic experience of the clone as the Other. The construction of a dystopian realm enables Ishiguro to articulate the theme of otherness, delineating the clones as the Other, in relation to a system of authority that governs their existence. The novel argues the problematic nature of loss in relation with the intrinsic desire to create and attach meaning to places – such as Hailsham – the English estate where the characters spend their early years of life. It is through Kathy's subjective narrative that we get an insight into a different facet of the cloning controversy, which alludes to the tendency we, as humans, have to apprehend everything on the grounds of binary oppositions, thus separating and dividing the human and the Other. This approach outlines the subjectivity and the constructedness of meaning-making through discourse and power, as the clones are pawns in a cruel structural system. Otherness is thus rendered primarily through the creation of a dystopian realm that ultimately shapes the way in which the clones come to think, behave, act, and perceive themselves and the world. Since the questions Ishiguro navigates are of an ethical nature, Hailsham is a continuation of the clones' existence; it might even be interpreted as an allegory, being deeply tied with the issue of identity.

The novel displays the moral and ethical implications of cloning, as a possible scenario, primarily due to the scientific advancement and discoveries of the second half of the 20th century. Since in 1996 the first sheep was successfully cloned in a laboratory, questioning the implications of such an action became inevitable, as scientific advancement can only go forward. These controversial issues, though, are debated in a subtle manner in the novel, through the creation of a greyish dystopian world, a euphemistic realm, one might argue, since third-party observers ought to analyse the depths of the topic as they are misled through the utilisation of specific phrases whose meanings are ambiguous. At a first, candid reading, the story might not seem too unnatural or unusual, as it renders the experiences of Kathy H. – the narrator of the text – and her friends, Tommy and Ruth, who, together, live at Hailsham. Kathy's introduction might be a source of confusion since she does not give her full name, which might indicate her belonging to a family. Instead, she starts her confession by talking about her experience and work as a *carer* – a word whose meaning the reader is not acquainted with at this point – but which introduces the idea of compassion.

Hailsham is gradually presented as a grand estate where the students grow up, mirroring some of the quintessential elements of the English tradition. It is interesting to note that Kathy does not clarify what Hailsham is, but the reader might deduce that it is either a boarding school or a type of orphanage since there is no mention of parents. Still, the presence of guardians who are the representatives of an unseen, unknown authority might allude to the dystopian genre the novel is affiliated with, although in a vague manner that might easily go unnoticed. We might argue that Hailsham, since it mirrors the essence of Englishness, represents a miniature realm, a personification of the country's values and system of beliefs, a simulacrum of self-contained civilisation, sheltering the students from the outer world. The guardians are keen to implement the standards of a typical English education, namely an orderly lifestyle depicted in the importance attributed to reading the classics and fostering the students' artistic inclinations. Being set in a remote, desolate landscape, Hailsham is a world on its own, a governmental structure whose purpose is to ensure that the students – who are cloned individuals – live by a very strict set of rules and regulations.

In reference to the time-frame when the plot develops, it is in the late second half of the 20th century, at a time of transition, when the influence of technology and science in people's lives started to become increasingly prevalent. Specifically, the action takes place in “the late 1990s” depicting the near past as a speculative scenario that might as well happen in the near future. The English cultural landscape is recognisable, if not relatable, delineating some of the most common motifs associated with the English countryside, exuding a sense of melancholy. This is precisely what Ishiguro wanted to recreate: the image of an England lacking colour, an England of “gray skies, flat, bare fields, drab streets, abandoned farms, empty roads (...) I wanted the kind of stark, chilling beauty I associate with remote rural areas and half-forgotten seaside towns” (Ishiguro, 2006: np). Gradually, the reader finds out that the students will leave the sheltering comfort of Hailsham at the age of sixteen, when they will begin their *training* so that they could donate their vital organs to sustain the lives of others. Most of the guardians at

Hailsham refrain from openly telling the students of the implications of their purpose as clones, apart from Miss Lucy, who honestly informs them about the way in which their lives are due to develop once they leave Hailsham:

... the problem as I see it is that you've been told and not told. You've been told, but none of you really understand, and I dare say, some people are quite happy to leave it that way. But I'm not. If you're going to have decent lives, then you've got to know and know properly. None of you will go to America, none of you will be film stars. And none of you will be working in the supermarkets as I heard some of you planning the other day. Your lives are set out for you. You'll become adults, then, before you're old, before you're even middle-aged, you'll start to donate your vital organs. That's what each of you was created to do. You're not like the actors you watch on your videos. You're not even like me. You were brought into this world for a purpose, and your futures, all of them, have been decided (Ishiguro, 2006: 76).

The fact that the clones are “told and not told” alludes to something that is quintessential of childhood and adolescence, and it is not exclusive to the lives of the clones, but to each and one of us. Our perception of the world, of others and of ourselves is moulded by what we are “told and not told” especially in the first years of life, which have a quintessential impact on creating given patterns of understanding, which demonstrates the unparalleled influence discourse has in our formation as individuals. Therefore, just as the students connect the dots in an attempt to deepen their comprehension of their own lives and the way in which their early adulthood will develop, the reader is also challenged to connect the bits of information Kathy gives as she relives all her years at Hailsham and then at the cottages. The narrative is constructed via the memories rendered by Kathy, memories that are far from being reliable. Consequently, the discourse is distorted by her biased perception. This is one of the reasons why the gradual development of the plot raises questions with each turn of the page. The cloning controversy is rendered on the background of a teenage drama, thus making it puzzling at times. However, this also allows us to peek into the inner struggles of the students, as they accept the lives that have been decided for them prior to their “birth.” Their willingness to embrace their fate as they do might be explained through the fact that they do not belong to a family, nor do they have someone to represent their cause, someone that would attest to their humanity and fight for their right to liberty. It is their status as *the Other* that marks their identity. The concept of identity is indeed constructed on the ground of difference, by placing the emphasis on the distinctions between two groups instead of focusing on the potential similarities. The ones that have access to discourse, being in the position to ensure its distribution and circulation have the means to expand their power and influence through the reinforcement of specific binary oppositions whose purpose is to consolidate given beliefs and, in the case of the clones in Ishiguro's novel, othering practices. As Judith Butler argues in her work *Precarious Life*, discourse, as a means of self-representation, is an influential tool that can be used to assert specific values.

Those who gain representation, especially self-representation, have a better chance of being humanized, and those who have no chance to represent themselves run a greater risk of being treated as less than human, regarded as less than human, or indeed, not regarded at all (Butler, 2004: 141).

The role played by discourse when assessing the constructed anatomy of identity is indisputable. As Foucault outlines in his work *Power/Knowledge*, “relations of power cannot themselves be established, consolidated, nor implemented without the production, accumulation, circulation and functioning of a discourse” (Foucault, 1980: 93). It is through the even and constant distribution of discourse that the guardians at Hailsham manage to establish specific patterns of thinking, so that the clones do not even consider the possibility of rebelling against the system. The three protagonists act as any other normal teenagers, struggling with day-to-day challenges associated with their age – such as the love triangle between the three characters – namely Kathy, Ruth and Tommy. Since the setting of the story is a beautiful, almost idyllic quintessentially English estate, the fact that we are dealing with a dystopian scenario is blurred. By presenting the lives of apparently *normal* teenagers and their daily struggles, Ishiguro makes the novel very relatable, in the sense that its readers are challenged to

sympathise with the characters, determining one to place himself/herself in the shoes of the characters, in this way ensuring a deeper, more profound comprehension of the issues argued in the text.

Hence, *Never Let Me Go* is not a dystopian work in the traditional sense of the word, the issues dealt with in the novel might be perceived as debatable, the author emphasising the dual character of technology and its omnipotence, mankind's dependence on and unparalleled faith in it, and the intrinsic desire to pursue self-preservation and comfort regardless the costs. In this way, by combining a so-called teenage love story with elements of the science fiction genre, Kazuo Ishiguro debates the implications of allowing the state to attain utter and complete control of the body by facilitating and financing programs that produce artificially created humans for organ transplants. Although the text does, indeed, allude to elements belonging to the science fiction genre – such as cloning – there are no actual descriptions or mentions of anything scientific per se. The semi-realist framework is the foundation on which Ishiguro constructs the plot of the novel by rendering quintessential themes such as the sense of loss, the quest for self-identification and the torment of living as a copy. As Kathy and Tommy learn in the final pages of the novel from Madame, the cloning program was established after the Second World War, at a time of uncertainty when humankind needed something to hold on to – in this case that *something* would be science – that would provide the possibility of living a carefree, disease-free existence. Therefore, the clones belong to the first generations of artificially created people, a project that was at the phase of experimentation. As actual components of England's National Health Service, they have relinquished the control of their own bodies, wishes and desires, denying their impulses to live life freely, and in this way abiding by the rules imposed by the Order. The Order is present in the form of Hailsham – the English estate Kathy loves so much –, in the embodiment of the guardians that teach and guide the students in their artistic and social endeavours. The overbearing presence of surveillance – a quintessential characteristic of dystopian fiction – is also present at Hailsham, as Kathy mentions in several accounts that she had to be very careful whenever she and Tommy spoke in privacy, as they could be seen from several parts of the estate.

The idea of being constantly watched by someone might be connected with Bentham's Panopticon – an innovative design of prisons consisting of a high tower that enabled the authority to watch over the prisoners round the clock and observe their every move. Panopticism entailed several regulations that had to be followed closely. In his work *Discipline and Punish. The Birth of a Prison*, Foucault traces back the way in which the complete control of the authority was implemented in an attempt to control the plague pandemic in the 17th century via the introduction of a very specific set of rules and regulations that restricted the liberty of the individual. As he puts it, during the pandemic, by applying Bentham's principle of absolute surveillance, the town and its surrounding districts were partitioned, whereas leaving town was completely prohibited. Another characteristic was the overbearing presence of inspectors that always carried out inspections to determine whether the rules were followed or not (Foucault, 1995: 225). It refers to regulating an “enclosed, segmented space, observed at every point, in which the individuals are inserted in a fixed space, in which the slightest movements are supervised” (ibid. 226). While the level of surveillance at Hailsham might not seem too evident – at first glance at the very least – Kathy does mention at times that she felt as if she was being watched from wherever. This is why she always had to choose just the right spot to discuss a more sensitive topic.

Another characteristic of panopticism, as emphasised by Foucault is the fact that the “surveillance is based on a system of permanent registration: reports from the syndics to the intendants, from the intendants to the magistrates or mayor” (ibid. 225). The bureaucratic control exercised by the authorities during the epidemic reflects the way in which discourse, or the written word in this case, can be successfully utilised as a tool to shape the existence of the people. While the *registration* of the students at Hailsham is not of the same nature, it is disguised in some of the guardians' habits. One might refer to Madame's practice of collecting art pieces belonging to the Hailsham students, and keeping them for exhibitions, as they were believed to represent the extensions of the clones' souls. Although the students had several theories regarding this practice, they never really pinpointed the reason behind this practice apart from Kathy and Tommy – to whom Madame herself divulged the truth in the last pages of the novel. Hence, the art was used to demonstrate the humanity of the clones, to change people's perception of the clones due to their intrinsic fear towards them. To encapsulate the essence of the Panopticon, as articulated by Foucault, its goal is to “induce in the inmate a state of conscious and permanent visibility that assures the automatic functioning of power” (ibid. 230). Of

utmost importance is the deindividualization of power, in the sense that the concept of authority should not relate to a singular entity; the representatives of authority may be interchangeable, so that the governance is ever-present, thus preserving its influence over the people.

A contradiction arises: while Hailsham facilitated a more human lifestyle for the clones, it displays, nonetheless, the characteristics of a dystopian realm governed by an unseen, universal system of power. What this shows is that power may appear disguised in different ways and forms – in some instances it is easier to observe whereas in others it is more problematic, but the tentacles of power outreach, many a time, our personal sphere of comprehension. The restraints imposed on the body by a third-party authority create a distance between the individual and his/her body, mirrored in the acceptance of their fate without even considering fighting against the inevitable – that of giving up existence in favour of *the others*, the ones who are considered worthy to live long, comfortable lives. Once again, we might refer to Foucault's work *Discipline and Punish. The Birth of the Prison*, as in his theory regarding the discipline and the restraints imposed on the body are a form of punishment imposed by an authority, a punishment that forces the individual to relinquish the right to his own body.

The body now serves as an instrument or intermediary: if one intervenes upon it to imprison it, or to make it work, it is in order to deprive the individual of a liberty that is regarded both as a right and as a property. The body, according to this penalty, is caught up in a system of constraints and privations, obligations and prohibitions. (Foucault, 1995: 19)

Although Hailsham does not come off as a prison, the restraints imposed on the lives of the clones – and implicitly on their bodies as well – are still there, portraying the dystopian nature of the estate. They are prohibited several liberties and rights they might have had if they had not been *students* at Hailsham, such as smoking or having children: “as we knew, it was completely impossible for any of us to have babies” (Ishiguro, 2006: 79). The sense of inferiority perpetuated by Kathy in this context alludes to the condition of the body as a commodity, as her right to have children is dismissed. In his work, Foucault navigates the punishment of the criminal and the way certain rituals have been changed and adopted throughout the centuries, the focus is placed on the act of redemption the criminal must undergo through actions of discipline. Each punishment is based on physical and mental restraint, causing pain to the body, whilst also having a long-term influence on his/her psychological wellbeing. In the case of the clones, their regrettable fate is not the impending result of someone willingly wronging someone else, but their regrettable fate has been decided by the anonymous representatives of the Order and they are incapable of fighting it.

Further, I would like to concentrate on the paradoxical nature of Hailsham as a dystopian realm. Although it is part of the cloning program belonging to the English National Health System, they treat the clones differently, more humanely, so to speak, teaching them with wariness and kindness that they should abide by the rules imposed on them. It was Miss Emily who disclosed the fact that Hailsham was established as a social experiment to attest to the humanity of the clones:

“When Marie-Claude and I started out, there were no places like Hailsham in existence. We were the first (...) Together we became a small but very vocal movement, and we challenged the entire way the donations programme was being run. (...) Before that, all clones – or students, as we preferred to call you – existed only to supply medical science. In the early days, after the war, that's largely all you were to most people. Shadowy objects in test tubes” (Ishiguro, 2006: 240-1)

Therefore, it is only logical for the students to recurrently display their fondness and attachment of Hailsham, as their time there enabled them to experience a feeling of safety and security. This is why the reader will find it disquieting when Miss Emily confesses about its mysterious purpose, that originally it was an experiment whose mission was to demonstrate to people that the clones are, indeed, human. Hailsham, as an estate, might be interpreted as a mirror of Englishness, of the essence of the English tradition and lifestyle, namely the appreciation and preservation of an orderly lifestyle, pursuing artistic and physical activities in order to ensure a balanced development of the individual. The fact that some of the clones had the opportunity to grow there was considered a unique, priceless blessing, something that granted them a sense of superiority over other clones – the ones who were not chosen or given the chance to be educated in such a civilised, beautiful estate. There were even rumours according to which the clones from Hailsham had the option of postponing their donations if they proved to the

ones in charge that they were in a committed, loving relationship. Simply put, proving that they had feelings towards another person would attest to the fact that they have souls – as this was something the guardians wanted to demonstrate by educating them to develop their artistic talents and inclinations.

Nonetheless, Hailsham encapsulates the very essence of deception, as everything there, starting from the beautiful estate, the gardens, the focus on education, poetry and art – all of it is just an attempt to sweeten the sour fate of the students. Additionally, Ishiguro carefully rendered the boarding school atmosphere that evokes a feeling of familiarity, thus granting the students the ideal background to tie bonds and lasting relationships – as is the case with Kathy, Ruth and Tommy. They have little habits and customs such as the exhibitions, buying artistic objects made by them in class, buying second hand objects in the *sale* – this kind of habits granted the students a sense of belonging to a bigger community that resembled a family, and it was due to this illusion that Kathy, Ruth and Tommy managed to remain somehow close regardless of the struggles they went through. The focus on tradition and the fact that the guardians gave the students credit when they created something beautiful, all these elements contributed to the construction of a system, an individualised structure of making meaning.

Kathy's narrative outlines her focus on her surroundings, and her passion of driving in the remote, desolate countryside as a therapeutic way of passing the time shows that being raised at Hailsham has shaped her perception. In this view, one could argue that the English character of Hailsham has played a key part, as well as its isolated position in the English countryside, which alludes to the desolate, marginalised status of the clones. According to Krishan Kumar, Englishness can be described as “a cultural rather than a political phenomenon” (Kumar, 2003: 252). It encapsulates everything English including “English history, English intellectual and political traditions, English literature and the landscape of England” (ibid.). He attempts to mark the distinction between the civic and ethnic element of Englishness, pointing out that the civic element is much more pronounced, emphasising that the English culture consists of a set of institutions, symbols and traditions that are almost irrevocably linked with the country's cultural identity. If we were to apply the concept of Englishness to Hailsham as an estate belonging to the country's medical and political system, we might conclude that the set of values and the focus on specific customs and traditions that are imbued with meaning portrays the essence of Englishness. What may strike us as being controversial is the guardians' intention to change the world's perception of the clones through art, as opposed to resorting to something more revolutionary. Their focus is placed on sheltering the students as much as possible, encouraging them to pursue their artistic endeavours and to keep their minds sharp. The students' connections with the world are merely superficial, since the information they get is filtered through the guardians' mechanism of critical thinking. The diversity of classes the students participate in at Hailsham is vast and it consists of literature, arts, geography, biology, but Kathy mentions something else, namely their attending a class entitled Culture Briefing. During these classes they had to practise basic social interaction with the people they might come across as carers. Basically, the students had to participate in different role-playing scenarios, alluding, once again to the nature of their existence – that of existing as copies – therefore they had to copy and enact *normal people's behaviours* so that they would not look suspicious, and would seamlessly blend in the social background.

3. The Fear of the Other

Humans have always had an intrinsic fear towards the unknown, since the unknown challenges us to think and do things differently than before, which does not provide any sense of assurance or comfort, quite the opposite. This is why, although the creation of the clones made people feel safe as it enabled them to fight diseases that were known as incurable until that point, it also made them frightened. Thus, the clones – perceived as the Other – were separated from society, placed in institutions and estates that were especially created for them. This separation inevitably deepens and amplifies the fear and unease experienced by the so-called normal people. In the final part of the novel, when Kathy and Tommy finally confront Miss Emily, openly asking her the questions they have been looking for answers for all their lives, she brings into discussion a renowned name in the scientific realm, James Morningdale, and the scientific experiments he conducted in Scotland. Humankind could not stop at creating clones in laboratories, the road to progress can only go forward, and the last pages of the novel mirror just that.

It concerned a scientist called James Morningdale, quite talented in his way. He carried on his work in a remote part of Scotland, where I suppose he thought he'd attract less attention. What he wanted was to offer the possibility of having children with enhanced characteristics. Superior intelligence, superior athleticism, that sort of thing. Of course, there'd been others with similar ambitions, but this Morningdale fellow, he'd taken his research much further than anyone before him, far beyond legal boundaries. Well, he has discovered, they put an end to his work and that seems to be that. (...) It reminded people, reminded them of a fear they'd always had. It's one thing to create students, such as yourself, for the donation programme. But a generation of created children who'd take their place in society? Children demonstrably superior to the rest of us? Oh no. That frightened people. They recoiled from that. (Ishiguro, 2006: 242-3)

As one can clearly observe in the paragraph above, the fear of the unknown is what, many times, determines people to act the way they do. The paragraph encapsulates the opposition between nature and science, delineating that the elimination of boundaries and limits in the scientific realm might inevitably lead to unwanted repercussions that would challenge us to redefine quintessential aspects such as humanity. The clones are addressed to as students; which is one of the most commonly met euphemisms in the novel, thus attempting to hide or conceal the real reason they have been created in the first place. Even if the people benefited from prolonged lifespan and the option of defying some of the most serious diseases such as cancer and heart disease, they still did not want to think of the existence of the clones as human beings with souls, reason and needs: "The world didn't want to be reminded how the donation programme really worked" (Ishiguro, 2006: 243). Instead, they repressed their knowledge of the real people behind the donation programme, the people who made it possible for them to defy nature and pursue self-preservation and enjoy a comfortable lifestyle. By granting technology supremacy over the ethical and moral implications of human cloning and organ harvesting, a new cult is created, the cult of relinquishing all ethical principles in the favour of self-preservation. This is what Ishiguro wants to emphasise, namely the possible effects of granting science unparalleled control over our lives. One consequence would be creating a sense of otherness in the anatomy of the society, leading to fear, division and conflict between the majority and the Other. When man takes on the role of a creator, one of the unavoidable repercussions is the fact that the creation – in our case the clones created in a laboratory – is perceived as the Other, and since the clones are scattered around the country depending completely on an invisible authority to provide them with the means to live comfortably, they are utterly incapable of revolting against the authority, against the people who are governing their lives from the shadow.

The people's fear of the clones is perpetuated due to their prejudiced attitude towards the students. Evidently, Madame witnessed the physical and psychological development of the students, she was there to see how they developed their artistic skills, creating poems, working on sculptures, and studying classic literary works. Despite all that, whenever she was in the presence of the students, she attempted to conceal a shudder, the terror of being in the proximity of a strange creature. Kathy points out that "Madame was afraid of us. But she was afraid of us in the same way someone might be afraid of spiders. We hadn't been ready for that. It had never occurred to us to wonder how we would feel, being seen like that, being the spiders" (Ishiguro, 2006: 35). This paragraph does not mean that Madame thought of the clones as she thought of animals, or the fact that spiders have anything in common with humanity whatsoever. What this paragraph emphasises is the fact that Madame is afraid of them because of their origin. Her fear doesn't equal hatred, but is actually connected with the similarity between the clones and the humans whilst also being inherently distinct in the way in which they came into existence: "there are people out there, like Madame, who don't hate you or wish you harm, but who nevertheless shudder at the very thought of you – of how you were brought into this world and why – and who dread the idea of your hand brushing against theirs" (ibid). It appears that Madame simply cannot help displaying her feelings as much as she tries to conceal them, because the copies of the originals – the simulacra – are living creatures, smart students capable of expressing complex thought and profound sentiment.

It is due to the perception of the clone as a simulacrum that the fear, the sense of the uncanny is continually perpetuated – not only by Madame, but by the guardians and by the world in general. It is an uncontrollable reflex potentially caused precisely by the fact that the human and the posthuman have so much in common, that the only element that differentiates the two might be the way in which they came into existence. The clone is produced from a single cell – a matrix – which provides the possibility

of endless multiplication, further deepening the alienation of the individual in a world dominated by simulacra. What seems to be an incomparable benefit, that of defeating incurable illnesses requires in-depth consideration as it involves the creation of the Other, and the perpetuation of the posthuman as the humans are implanted organs derived from the clones, thus expanding the effect of alienation. Considering that the essence of what makes one human has been encapsulated into a matrix, this alludes to the deconstructedness of the human body, as it has been condensed into something reproducible, this triggering the uncanny – the mixture of familiarity and unease.

4. Living as a Copy

When exploring the human character of the clones – who were copied after other people – we might allude to the aspect of copying, which refers to one of the inherent impulses of the human race. According to Fuss, a way of characterising identity would be: “that detour through the other that defines a self” (Fuss, 1995: 2). Therefore, when defining the concept of identity, we inevitably relate to those in our proximity to comprehend ourselves, this also impacting how our conception is shaped in the most complex matters. Without realising it, we take in what we see, read and experience and transfer all that information on a subconscious level, as other people’s presence in our lives will, to a given extent, contour our individuality or lack of individuality. As for the group of artificially created students in the novel, they do not have any roots whatsoever; being copied after people they have no knowledge of. And this aspect has a defining characteristic in terms of their understanding of selfhood.

Being compelled to enact the role of normal individuals, they constantly experience a feeling of inferiority, which is partly the result of their upbringing as clones regarded as less than human. Their perception of themselves has been constructed on the foundation of marginality, the sense of which has been implanted in their subconscious. As human copies, they are created for a purely utilitarian purpose. Simultaneously, living as a copy leads to the establishment of a strong sense of alienation between the body and experiences as a human. The idea that you belong to someone else led to the creation of a joke at Hailsham: “The idea was that when the time came you would be able to unzip a bit of yourself, a kidney or something would slide out, and you’d hand it over. It wasn’t something we found so funny in itself; it was more a way of putting each other off our food” (Ishiguro, 2006: 82). The way in which the students related to their bodies implied a sense of awkwardness and unease, and this related to their existence as the Other. Being disposable as individuals delineates the fact that the ones in charge negate their subjectivity and individuality. This creates a contradiction, since, in spite of the way in which the students came into existence, they did not differ that much from the *rest of the world* in terms of selfhood. Since their perception of selfhood is overshadowed by a permanent sense of inferiority, the students seem to accept this self-induced inferiority, as, deep down, they acknowledge the very fact that they are regarded as replaceable beings.

What I would like to bring into discussion is the recurring theme of exchange, rendering the concept that almost everything encapsulates an exchange value, alluding to the commodity status of the clones’ body, of their sculptures, paintings, and other collectable items. The sales that are organised on a regular basis at Hailsham consisting of objects whose utility has been dismissed by their former owners could also be analysed from a symbolic angle. The objects that were so highly treasured by the students have been discarded as useless – maybe even as junk – by their previous owners. Nonetheless, the students anticipate these regular events since it allows them to start or expand a personal collection of items, items that would eventually be embedded with significance – such as Kathy’s precious tape with the song *Never let me go*. Concurrently, another regular event alluding to the inherent value of things and the way in which biased perception of commodities impacts their value would be the *exchanges* that are organised at Hailsham four times a year. These events included the students’ best work consisting of things they have created such as poems, sculptures and other objects made from all sorts of things including trash. Since many of those objects were made from unusable stuff or, simply put, from trash, once again renders the recurring theme of the novel, namely the dispensability of the clones as they relinquish control over their own bodies. It is also a euphemism to refer to these objects as being artistic, since there were only a few creations that were considered worthy to be displayed in Madame’s Gallery. Regarding the artistic endeavours of the clones, it is interesting to note that the guardians insist that the students foster their artistic talents, since Madame – an authoritative figure whose presence is surrounded by mystery each time she is present – gathers the best work belonging to the clones, without

anyone knowing why. Later on, we find out that the reason Madame collected the best work of the students was to validate their humanity, so that the people would see that they are just like them, that they do have souls, although most people – including the guardians, questioned their humanity.

Since the students were not told a lot, they had several theories and they connected what their guardians did tell them to make up potential stories. Kathy and Tommy have several talks debating the things they were told by Miss Lucy for instance, concerning Tommy's artistic endeavours, whether he should pursue them or not, regardless of his apparent lack of talent. But a theory that is mostly relevant for the theme of the novel is that concerning the clones' *possibles*. Once again, Ishiguro resorts to utilising a euphemistic phrase, *a possible* being a person after which one of the clones is modelled.

The basic idea behind the possibles theory was simple, and didn't provoke much dispute. It went something like this. Since each of us was copied at some point from a normal person, there must be, for each of us, somewhere out there, a model getting on with his or her life. This meant, at least in theory, you'd be able to find the person you were modelled from. That's why, when you went out there yourself – in the towns, shopping centres, transport cafes – you kept an eye out for 'possibles' – the people who might have been the models for you and your friends. (Ishiguro, 2006: 127)

The obsession of the clones to look for *possibles* is exemplified in the episode when they visit Norfolk – the hidden corner of England they presupposed old unused stuff ended up – another assumption made by the students after a lesson of geography held by one of the guardians. The reason why finding a *possible* way out seemed so appealing to the clones was because this would give them a sense of the place they came from, a sense of belonging to someone else in the world, maybe to experience that they are part of a family. By belonging to someone else, they could redefine their identity and selfhood, something they perpetually attempt to do by copying what they see other people do – in real life, magazines, TV shows or books. It appears that Ishiguro focuses on the way in which as an individual – especially in the first phases of life – during childhood and adolescence, one has an inherent inclination to copy what he/she sees in their immediate proximity, as this makes them feel included. Donald Winnicott is a renowned psychologist, the author of the psychological theory of the True and the False Self, accentuating the importance of the first years of life in the development of an autonomous individual. Thus, the true self is characterised by authenticity, the infant being fully dependent on his mother to confirm and support expressions of omnipotence (Winnicott, 1990: 145). Hence, the infant's ego is strengthened if the mother responds to her child's needs, making the infant believe in the existence of a magic, external reality. Due to the illusion of omnipotence, the infant is now eager to control and to create, which is, of course, associated with the act of imagination.

On the other hand, it is a false self that emerges when the mother's response is not good enough, the infant resorting to constructing a false set of relationships, imitation being its dominant characteristic. According to Winnicott, identification will eventually come to replace authenticity, in the sense that copied gestures and habits will come to substitute real, authentic ones, until the point one loses grasp of reality, as the action of imitation becomes prevalent in the person's life (ibid. 147). The influence of the mother – the person that spends the most time with the child especially in the first years of his/her life – is paramount, the mother fully identifying with her child; it is through her devotion that the child will develop his/her true self, which eventually will come into conflict with the *false self* (ibid. 148). In *Never Let Me Go*, as the presence of the mother is inexistent in the lives of the children, the existence of a spontaneous, authentic true self in the early stage of their lives is null, this fact shaping their perception of selfhood. The absence of a devoted caregiver will result in the creation of the *false self*, the mind conceiving a substitute to replace what it missed in the early phase of infancy.

The concept of 'A False Self' needs to be balanced by a formulation of that which could properly be called the True Self. At the earliest stage the True Self is the theoretical position from which come the spontaneous gesture and the personal idea. The spontaneous gesture is the True Self in nature. Only the True Self can be creative and only the True Self can feel real. Whereas a True Self feels real, the existence of a False Self results in a feeling unreal or a sense of futility. The False Self, if successful in its function, hides the True Self, or else finds a way of enabling the True Self to start to live (Winnicott, 1990: 148).

We might observe the characteristics of the *false self* in the personality of the clones, in their own perception of identification. The clones appear to simulate what they see in their proximity, copying what passes as normal and acceptable in a socially acceptable realm, in this way constructing and afterwards passing on specific behaviour patterns. Not only are the students copied after *others*, but their entire lives are also based on acts of imitation; they imitate based on instinct, assuming that this is what they are supposed to do in order to fit it, in order to belong. The infant, guarded and protected by the mother, will gradually develop complexity, going through each natural process, being capable to “react to a stimulus without trauma because the stimulus has a counterpart in the individual’s inner, psychic reality” (Winnicott, 1990: 149). Nevertheless, in reference to the *false self*, the infant will embrace an adaptable behaviour, having a flexible approach to the outside realm, since “subjectivity precedes externality (...) this translates into the commonly held assumption that projective mechanisms precede the experience of independence or otherness” (Hamilton, 2007: 386). Hence, the clones experience the outside world having a very limited comprehension of it, which is heavily impacted by their mental and physical imprisonment. This effectively nullifies the possibility of *breaking through* the infrastructural realm in which they are confined.

Thus, the students resort to absorbing what they see other people do in this way constructing a *false self*. When they are already living at the Cottages, Ruth starts to pick up all kinds of gestures and ticks she notices while watching American TV shows. Implementing them looks forced and unnatural; yet, in a desperate desire to act as if she were a normal person, to act as if she were *the other*, she keeps on doing it: “It looks daft, the way you copy everything they do” (Ishiguro, 2006: 113). It is not that Ishiguro intends to portray the clones as copiers whilst the others are original and authentic. Quite the contrary, humans are inherent copiers as well, taking in and absorbing what they see, be it phrases, colloquial discourse, social behaviour, or mannerisms, thus marking the similitude between the clones and *normal people*. As Ruth gets overly excited about the prospect of finding her *possible*, she constructs the illusion in her mind after having seen an advertisement with cheerful, happy people working in an office. She takes in this image and moulds it to her own life, to her *possible*, creating something that she would find ultimately appealing, a delusional image, as she stubbornly tries to complete her story and speculate on her origin, attempting to cope with loss in a dystopian reality through meaning-making. When Ruth and the others realise that Ruth’s *possible* was merely an illusion, as there was no resemblance between the two, she is overwhelmed with disappointment.

“A bit of fun for you, maybe, Tommy,” Ruth said coldly, still gazing straight ahead of her. “You wouldn’t think so if it was *your possible* we’d been looking for.”
 “I think I would,” Tommy said. “I don’t see how it matters. Even if you found your *possible*, the actual model they got you from. Even then, I don’t see what difference it makes to anything.”
 (Ishiguro, 2006: 151)

Since the students knew absolutely nothing about the people after which they were modelled, it is easy to understand why they felt lost and the fact that their impulse of copying whatever they saw around them ultimately defined their individuality. Ruth’s idealised version of her future – if she were granted the possibility to have one – corresponded with the life of the *possible* found in Norfolk. She was working in an office, in a positive environment that was similar to the image portrayed in the advertisement she had seen. This effectively attests to the power of imagery in shaping the individual’s pattern of thinking, as well as the clones’ inherent inclination to copy and absorb what the world presents as normal and, afterwards, reproduce it for validation.

5. Conclusion

Never Let Me Go explores the multifaceted character of identity, bioethics and cloning, whilst still delineating the simplest, rawest expressions of humanity, in this way triggering the outburst of a conglomeration of questions that determine the reader to draw some conclusions. As technological advancement is a reality, we cannot escape it is quintessential to assess whether these are truths we accept as indubitable or not. This was my stance as a reader, continually trying to answer questions, to come up with answers or solutions, or simply to acknowledge that there is no solution whatsoever. Kazuo Ishiguro makes the reader go through a plethora of emotions – the trauma experienced by Kathy

is tangible, the pain described when she goes to Norfolk to be in the place where she imagined all her childhood memories had washed away – it's perceptible at the deepest, most profound level, her tears are there, present, yet still kept under control. Perhaps the most controversial aspect of human cloning lies in its promise to bring safety and security to a world that lacks them. Nonetheless, this is the exact opposite to what it manages to provide, as it generates loss, trauma, pain and separation, as the promotion and implementation of a self-preservation policy might ultimately dismiss humanity as a notion synonymous with kindness and affection. Yet how do we define humanity? Or could we attempt to define it? Is a clone automatically non-human since it was produced in a laboratory, due to the fact that its identity can be encapsulated in a matrix that may be reproduced for endless times? The intrinsic inclination of both humans and clones to copy and assimilate various behavioural elements utterly highlights the sameness between the two. The likeness is visibly present, whereas the constructedness of otherness is present as well, yet what will the reader choose to focus on out of the two?

The approach of my research, as I concentrated on the marked character of otherness of the clone – as the posthuman or non-human – in relation to the original – as the human or the normal –, has alluded to the way in which our comprehension of humanity may be constructed on the principle of normativity, as a guiding principle that shapes collective thinking patterns. Hence, Ishiguro's novel emphasises that what we may assess as truthful might not be so, on the grounds of the humans' way of treating the clones, which is effectively inhuman, since they are disposed like objects, their physical bodies being used as commodities created for a very specific practical purpose.

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